



GOVERNANCE DOCUMENT

Assessment and Examination Policy

International Society of Equity Analysts

DOCUMENT VERSION

1.2

DATE APPROVED

1 July 2025

LAST UPDATED

1 July 2026

ADMINISTERED BY

Education and Certification
Committee

Document Control

DOCUMENT OWNER	Education and Certification Committee
APPROVAL AUTHORITY	Governing Council
ADMINISTERED BY	Education and Certification Committee
DATE APPROVED	1 July 2025
LAST UPDATED	1 July 2026
DOCUMENT VERSION	1.2
NEXT REVIEW DATE	1 July 2027
RELATED DOCUMENTS	Member Admission Framework Membership Regulations Membership Policy Ethics Policy Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct Conflict of Interest Policy Complaints Policy Disciplinary Policy Whistleblower Policy Document Retention Policy Privacy Policy

This document forms part of the official governance framework of the International Society of Equity Analysts (ISEA) and should be read together with the related documents listed above.

Contents

1. Purpose	4
2. Scope and Application	4
3. Relationship with Other ISEA Documents	5
4. Definitions and Interpretation	5
5. Overview of the Equity Research Assessment	6
6. Eligibility to Undertake Assessment	7
7. Assessment Administration	8
8. Reasonable Adjustments	9
9. Assessment and Examination Integrity	10
10. Examination and Assessment Misconduct	11
11. Plagiarism and Research Integrity	12
12. Use of Artificial Intelligence and Technology	13
13. Conflicts of Interest	13
14. Assessors	14
15. Marking	15
16. Moderation	18
17. Reassessment	18
18. Appeals	19
19. Confidentiality	20
20. Retention of Assessment Records	21
21. Review and Continuous Improvement	22
22. Effective Date	22

1. Purpose

The International Society of Equity Analysts (“ISEA” or “the Society”) is committed to maintaining a rigorous, credible and internationally consistent system for assessing the competence of individuals seeking admission as a Member of the International Society of Equity Analysts (“MISEA”), and for assessing individuals who are otherwise required to undertake or repeat an assessment under ISEA’s Membership Regulations, this Policy or another applicable ISEA requirement.

This Assessment and Examination Policy (“Policy”) establishes the principles, standards, roles and procedures governing the design, administration, marking, moderation and integrity of the Equity Research Assessment and any other assessment or examination administered by ISEA for the purposes of membership admission, progression or reassessment.

The Equity Research Assessment is the central competency assessment for MISEA admission and, as set out in the Member Admission Framework, consists of:

- (a) two 2 equity research reports, comprising one report assigned by ISEA (ISEA-Assigned Research Report) and one report selected by the applicant in accordance with the requirements prescribed by ISEA “Applicant-Selected Research Report”
- (b) an oral defence of the submitted research (Oral Defence)
- (c) a controlled written case examination (Controlled Written Case Examination) and
- (d) any additional assessment approved by ISEA (Additional Assessment)
- (e) together, the (Equity Research Assessment)

This Policy exists to ensure that the Equity Research Assessment, and any other assessment to which this Policy applies, is administered fairly, consistently, securely and with integrity, so that the professional designations awarded by ISEA continue to represent a meaningful and internationally credible recognition of professional competence in equity research and investment analysis.

This Policy operationalises the assessment provisions of the Member Admission Framework and should be read together with that Framework, the Membership Regulations and the other ISEA policies referred to in this Policy.

2. Scope and Application

This Policy applies to:

- (a) applicants for MISEA admission who are required to undertake the Equity Research Assessment
- (b) existing Members required to undertake reassessment, a supplementary assessment or an additional assessment under the Membership Regulations, this Policy, the Disciplinary Policy or another applicable ISEA requirement
- (c) the Governing Council, to the extent it exercises oversight, appellate or approval functions under this Policy
- (d) the Membership and Chapters Committee and the Education and Certification Committee or such other committee as the Governing Council may designate to oversee assessment matters “Responsible Committee”
- (e) Assessment Panels, assessors, moderators, invigilators and examiners appointed or engaged by ISEA
- (f) officers and employees of the Executive Secretariat involved in the administration of assessments and
- (g) any contractor, vendor or third-party service provider engaged by ISEA to support the design, delivery, invigilation, marking or security of an assessment.

A person to whom this Policy applies is referred to in this Policy as a “Candidate” where undertaking or seeking to undertake an assessment, and as an “Assessment Participant” where performing an administrative, assessing, moderating or invigilating function under this Policy.

This Policy applies to the Equity Research Assessment and to any other examination, assessment, reassessment or supplementary assessment administered by ISEA for the purposes of membership admission, progression, reinstatement or continuing eligibility, except to the extent that another ISEA policy or the Membership Regulations expressly provides otherwise.

This Policy does not, by itself, establish substantive eligibility requirements for any category of ISEA membership. Eligibility requirements are established by the Membership Regulations and the Member Admission Framework. This Policy governs the manner in which assessment is designed, administered and evaluated once a Candidate becomes eligible to undertake it.

Nothing in this Policy limits the application of the Disciplinary Policy, the Complaints Policy, the Whistleblower Policy or the Ethics Policy to conduct occurring in connection with an assessment.

3. Relationship with Other ISEA Documents

This Policy operates within, and must be interpreted consistently with, the following hierarchy of ISEA governing documents:

- (a) the ISEA Charter is the highest governing document of ISEA and prevails over all other ISEA documents
- (b) the Membership Regulations are binding rules made pursuant to the authority of the Charter and prevail over this Policy
- (c) the Membership and Chapters Committee Charter establishes the authority, responsibilities and governance arrangements of the Membership and Chapters Committee and prevails over any administrative procedure or practice inconsistent with its terms
- (d) the Membership Policy establishes the principles, objectives and strategic approach governing membership matters and must be interpreted consistently with the Charter, the Membership Regulations and the Committee Charter and
- (e) the Member Admission Framework establishes the operational requirements, eligibility pathways, assessment components, marking allocation and pass requirements applicable to MISEA admission, and this Policy must be read and applied consistently with that Framework.

Where any inconsistency exists between this Policy and a document referred to above, the document higher in the hierarchy prevails, and this Policy applies only to the extent that it is consistent with those documents.

This Policy should also be read together with the Ethics Policy and the Code of Ethics and Standards of Professional Conduct" Code", which establish the ethical framework applicable to Candidates and Assessment Participants the Conflict of Interest Policy, which governs the identification and management of conflicts of interest arising in connection with an assessment the Complaints Policy and the Disciplinary Policy, which govern the investigation and resolution of alleged misconduct the Whistleblower Policy, which establishes protected channels for reporting suspected wrongdoing the Document Retention Policy, which establishes minimum retention periods for organisational records generally and the Privacy Policy, which governs the handling of personal information collected in connection with an assessment.

Where a matter relating to an assessment is also addressed by one of the policies referred to above, both this Policy and the other applicable policy shall apply, and the more specific or more stringent requirement shall prevail unless doing so would be inconsistent with a document higher in the hierarchy referred to in Clause 3.1.

4. Definitions and Interpretation

In this Policy, unless the context otherwise requires:

- (a) **"Additional Assessment"** means any assessment component approved by ISEA in addition to the two Equity Research Reports, the Oral Defence and the Controlled Written Case Examination, whether applicable generally or to a specific admission pathway.

- (b) **“Assessment Panel”** means the panel of assessors, moderators and other persons appointed by the Responsible Committee to design, administer, mark or moderate an assessment under this Policy.
- (c) **“Assessment Participant”** means a person performing an administrative, assessing, moderating, invigilating or examining function under this Policy, including an assessor, moderator, invigilator, examiner, Assessment Panel member or member of the Executive Secretariat.
- (d) **“Assessment Record”** means any record generated in connection with an assessment, including a Candidate’s submissions, marking sheets, moderation records, correspondence, declarations, recordings and appeal records.
- (e) **“Assessor”** means a person appointed under Clause 14 to mark, evaluate or examine a Candidate’s performance in an assessment component.
- (f) **“Candidate”** means a person undertaking or seeking to undertake an assessment to which this Policy applies.
- (g) **“Controlled Written Case Examination”** means the supervised written case examination referred to in Clause 18 of the Member Admission Framework and Clause 9 of this Policy.
- (h) **“Equity Research Assessment”** means the assessment described in Clause 1.3 of this Policy and Clause 15 of the Member Admission Framework.
- (i) **“Examination Misconduct”** has the meaning given in Clause 10.
- (j) **“Invigilator”** means a person appointed or engaged by ISEA to supervise a Candidate’s conduct during the Controlled Written Case Examination, whether in person or by remote proctoring.
- (k) **“Moderator”** means a person appointed under Clause 16 to review the consistency, fairness and defensibility of marking outcomes.
- (l) **“Oral Defence”** means the oral defence of a Candidate’s submitted equity research reports referred to in Clause 17 of the Member Admission Framework and Clause 8 of this Policy.
- (m) **“Plagiarism”** has the meaning given in Clause 11.
- (n) **“Reasonable Adjustment”** means a modification to the standard conditions or format of an assessment, made in accordance with Clause 8, that does not compromise the integrity or validity of the assessment.
- (o) **“Responsible Committee”** means the Membership and Chapters Committee and the Education and Certification Committee, or such other committee as the Governing Council may from time to time designate to oversee assessment matters under this Policy.

Terms used but not defined in this Policy have the meaning given to them in the Member Admission Framework, the Membership Regulations or the Charter, as applicable. Headings in this Policy are for convenience only and do not affect interpretation. A reference to a Clause is a reference to a Clause of this Policy unless otherwise stated.

5. Overview of the Equity Research Assessment

5.1 Purpose of Assessment

The purpose of the Equity Research Assessment is to determine, to a professionally defensible standard, whether a Candidate can independently perform professional equity analysis at the standard expected of a MISEA Member, having regard to the MISEA Competency Standards set out in Appendix A to the Member Admission Framework.

5.2 Design Principles

ISEA shall design each component of the Equity Research Assessment, and any other assessment to which this Policy applies, so as to:

- (a) minimise the opportunity for plagiarism and other forms of academic or professional misconduct

- (b) test the Candidate's independent analytical capability, rather than the capability of any other person or system
- (c) verify authorship and understanding of submitted work through the Oral Defence and, where applicable, other verification measures
- (d) test technical competence, professional judgement and ethical reasoning and
- (e) ensure reasonable consistency of standard, difficulty and marking treatment between Candidates and between assessment cycles.

5.3 Components

Unless a pathway-specific assessment treatment has been approved in accordance with the Member Admission Framework and the Membership Regulations, every Candidate undertaking the Equity Research Assessment must complete all of the following components:

- (f) the ISEA-Assigned Research Report
- (g) the Applicant-Selected Research Report
- (h) the Oral Defence of both research reports and
- (i) the Controlled Written Case Examination.

Clauses 6 to 20 of this Policy establish the eligibility, administrative, integrity, marking, moderation, reassessment, appeal, confidentiality and record-retention requirements applicable to these components. The substantive content, format and page-length requirements applicable to the research reports, the format of the Oral Defence and the format of the Controlled Written Case Examination are established by the Member Admission Framework and by assessment guidance published by ISEA from time to time consistently with that Framework.

5.4 No Automatic Exemption

No admission pathway, professional qualification, academic qualification or professional achievement shall, by itself, exempt a Candidate from the Equity Research Assessment, except to the extent that an exemption or modified assessment treatment is expressly authorised under the Membership Regulations or approved by the Governing Council in accordance with those Regulations. Any such exemption or modified treatment must remain sufficient to establish the professional competence required for MISEA admission and must be documented in the Candidate's Assessment Record.

6. Eligibility to Undertake Assessment

6.1 Prerequisite Conditions

A Candidate may not be admitted to the Equity Research Assessment unless ISEA has confirmed that the Candidate:

- (a) has submitted a complete application for MISEA admission in accordance with the Member Admission Framework
- (b) has satisfied Stage 1 Application and Pathway Review and Stage 2 Evidence and Experience Verification of the membership admission process, or, in the case of a reassessment or other assessment to which this Policy applies, has satisfied any equivalent prerequisite determined by ISEA
- (c) has provided the referee, qualification, experience and other evidence applicable to the admission pathway relied upon
- (d) has made the declarations required under Clause 21.3 of the Member Admission Framework and Clause 9.4 of this Policy
- (e) has paid all applicable assessment fees and
- (f) is not subject to a current suspension, disqualification or restriction from undertaking an ISEA assessment.

6.2 Registration and Deadlines

ISEA shall publish, and may from time to time update, the registration windows, submission deadlines and examination dates applicable to each assessment cycle. A Candidate is responsible for registering for assessment, and for submitting all required materials, within the applicable timeframes. ISEA may decline to admit a Candidate to an assessment component where the Candidate has failed to register or submit materials within the applicable timeframe, except where an extension has been granted under Clause 7.6 or a Reasonable Adjustment has been granted under Clause 8.

6.3 Number of Attempts

A Candidate may undertake the Equity Research Assessment, or a component of it, subject to the limits on the number of attempts and the waiting periods between attempts established under Clause 17 of this Policy. Nothing in this Clause creates an entitlement to an unlimited number of attempts.

6.4 Identity Verification

A Candidate must provide satisfactory evidence of identity before undertaking any component of the Equity Research Assessment, whether the component is conducted in person or remotely. ISEA may require a Candidate to verify their identity again at any point during an assessment where reasonably necessary.

7. Assessment Administration

7.1 Responsible Committee Oversight

The Responsible Committee is accountable to the Governing Council for the overall integrity, quality and consistency of the Equity Research Assessment and any other assessment to which this Policy applies. The Responsible Committee may delegate day-to-day administration to an Assessment Panel, a certification manager within the Executive Secretariat, or another authorised body, but shall retain oversight of assessment policy, standards and outcomes.

7.2 Company Assignment

ISEA shall select the company to be analysed for the ISEA-Assigned Research Report, having regard to industry and sector diversity, geographical location, market capitalisation, complexity of the business, availability of public information, suitability for valuation analysis and the competencies intended to be assessed. ISEA shall notify the Candidate of the assigned company and the applicable submission period in writing.

7.3 Applicant-Selected Company Approval

A Candidate must submit the company proposed for the Applicant-Selected Research Report for ISEA's approval within the timeframe prescribed by ISEA. ISEA may reject a proposed company on any ground set out in Clause 16.5 of the Member Admission Framework, including insufficient public information, unsuitability for meaningful analysis, a material conflict of interest, or any other ground ISEA considers relevant to the integrity of the assessment. Where a proposed company is rejected, the Candidate must submit an alter

native company for approval within a further timeframe determined by ISEA.

7.4 Scheduling of the Oral Defence and Controlled Written Case Examination

ISEA shall notify a Candidate in writing of the date, time and place or, where conducted remotely, the applicable platform and access details of the Oral Defence not less than seven 7 days in advance, consistently with Clause 17.1 of the Member Admission Framework. ISEA shall provide equivalent reasonable notice of the date, time, location and format of the Controlled Written Case Examination.

7.5 Mode of Delivery

Each component of the Equity Research Assessment may be administered in person or, where ISEA is satisfied that it can implement appropriate identity verification, invigilation and integrity safeguards, by videoconference or another form of remote or electronically supervised delivery. ISEA shall determine the

mode of delivery applicable to a given assessment cycle or Candidate, having regard to the availability of secure infrastructure, the Candidate's location, any approved Reasonable Adjustment, and the integrity requirements of Clause 9.

7.6 Deferral, Extension and Withdrawal

A Candidate may apply to ISEA for a deferral of an assessment date, an extension of a submission deadline, or withdrawal from an assessment cycle, supported by appropriate evidence where the request relates to illness, bereavement, a natural disaster, a technical failure outside the Candidate's control, or another circumstance ISEA considers reasonable. ISEA may grant, grant subject to conditions, or refuse such a request, having regard to the reason given, the evidence provided, the stage of the assessment cycle, and the integrity and fairness of the assessment process for all Candidates. Where a request is refused, the Candidate may raise the matter through the Complaints Policy.

7.7 Technical and Administrative Failures

Where an assessment is disrupted by a technical failure, administrative error, or other circumstance not attributable to the Candidate, ISEA may, as it considers appropriate, extend the time allowed, reschedule the affected component, disregard a portion of the affected submission, or take such other action as is necessary to ensure the Candidate is not unfairly disadvantaged. ISEA shall document any such action in the Candidate's Assessment Record.

7.8 Fees

Candidates must pay the assessment fees determined by ISEA from time to time. Payment of an assessment fee does not guarantee a particular outcome and does not, by itself, create an entitlement to admission, a pass result or reassessment.

8. Reasonable Adjustments

8.1 Commitment to Accessibility

ISEA is committed to ensuring that its assessment processes are accessible to Candidates with disability, medical conditions or other circumstances that may affect their ability to undertake an assessment under standard conditions, while maintaining the integrity, validity and comparability of the Equity Research Assessment for all Candidates.

8.2 Requesting an Adjustment

A Candidate seeking a Reasonable Adjustment must submit a written request to ISEA, together with supporting evidence, as early as practicable and, in any event, within the timeframe published by ISEA for the relevant assessment cycle. Late requests may be considered where the need for adjustment arises unexpectedly or could not reasonably have been identified earlier.

8.3 Types of Adjustment

Depending on the nature of the request and the evidence provided, a Reasonable Adjustment may include, without limitation:

- (a) additional time to complete the Controlled Written Case Examination or another timed component
- (b) scheduled rest breaks during an assessment
- (c) the use of assistive technology or adaptive equipment
- (d) provision of assessment materials in an alternative format
- (e) an alternative assessment venue or environment and
- (f) such other adjustment as ISEA considers appropriate in the circumstances.

8.4 Evidence

ISEA may require a Candidate to provide supporting documentation, which may include evidence from a medical practitioner, allied health professional or other appropriately qualified person, sufficient to

establish the nature of the Candidate's circumstances and the adjustment reasonably required. ISEA shall handle such documentation in accordance with the Privacy Policy and Clause 19 of this Policy.

8.5 Assessment of Requests

ISEA shall assess each request for a Reasonable Adjustment on its individual merits, having regard to the evidence provided, the nature of the assessment component, and the need to preserve the validity, comparability and integrity of the assessment. ISEA may grant an adjustment in whole or in part, propose an alternative adjustment, or decline a request where it is not satisfied that the adjustment is reasonable, necessary or compatible with the integrity of the assessment. ISEA shall notify the Candidate in writing of its decision, including reasons where an adjustment is declined or modified.

8.6 Review

A Candidate who is dissatisfied with a decision under this Clause may request review of that decision in accordance with the Complaints Policy. Clause 8 is not subject to the Appeals procedure in Clause 18, which relates to assessment outcomes rather than administrative decisions concerning Reasonable Adjustments.

9. Assessment and Examination Integrity

9.1 General Principle

The value of the MISEA designation depends upon the integrity of the assessment process. Every Candidate and Assessment Participant is responsible for protecting that integrity and for conducting themselves in a manner consistent with this Policy, the Ethics Policy and the Code.

9.2 Research Independence

Consistently with Clause 16.6 of the Member Admission Framework, both equity research reports submitted by a Candidate must: represent the Candidate's own analysis and writing reflect independent professional judgement be prepared specifically for the Equity Research Assessment disclose material sources and analytical assumptions not materially reproduce research prepared by another person and comply with ISEA's research integrity requirements generally.

9.3 Examination Conditions

The Controlled Written Case Examination shall be conducted under controlled conditions, whether in person or by remote supervision, including identity verification, invigilation or proctoring, and such monitoring measures as ISEA considers necessary to detect unauthorised assistance, unauthorised materials or unauthorised use of technology. A Candidate must not bring into, access or use during the Controlled Written Case Examination any material, device, application, communication tool or other aid not expressly authorised by ISEA for that examination.

9.4 Candidate Declarations

Before undertaking the Equity Research Assessment, a Candidate must declare, consistently with Clause 21.3 of the Member Admission Framework, that: the information provided in the Candidate's application is accurate and complete the submitted research represents the Candidate's own work any assistance, sources or tools used, including any use of artificial intelligence, have been accurately and completely disclosed the Candidate understands and agrees to comply with ISEA's assessment requirements, including this Policy and the Candidate understands the consequences of a breach of this Policy, including under Clause 10.

9.5 Confidentiality of Assessment Content

Assessment questions, case materials, marking rubrics and other assessment content are the confidential property of ISEA. A Candidate must not reproduce, distribute, disclose, discuss or otherwise share such content with any other person, other than as expressly permitted by ISEA, before, during or after an assessment. A breach of this Clause may constitute Examination Misconduct under Clause 10 and may also constitute a breach of the Ethics Policy.

9.6 Verification of Authorship

The Oral Defence forms an integral part of the Equity Research Assessment and exists, among other purposes, to verify that a Candidate personally prepared the submitted research, understands the analytical methodology applied, and can explain and defend the assumptions, valuation approach and conclusions contained in both reports. ISEA may also use similarity-detection tools, cross-referencing against prior submissions, and such other verification measures as it considers appropriate to protect assessment integrity.

10. Examination and Assessment Misconduct

10.1 Definition

“Examination Misconduct” means conduct by a Candidate, or by another person acting on a Candidate’s behalf or with a Candidate’s knowledge, that undermines or is intended to undermine the integrity, security or fairness of an assessment. Examination Misconduct includes, but is not limited to:

- (a) impersonation of a Candidate, or arranging for another person to undertake any part of an assessment on the Candidate’s behalf
- (b) unauthorised collaboration with another person in the preparation of a research report or during the Controlled Written Case Examination
- (c) possession or use of unauthorised materials, devices or applications during a controlled or supervised assessment component
- (d) obtaining, disclosing, distributing or receiving confidential assessment content in breach of Clause 9.5
- (e) Plagiarism, as defined in Clause 11
- (f) undisclosed or unauthorised use of artificial intelligence or other technology, in breach of Clause 12
- (g) falsification or fabrication of data, sources, evidence, referee information or other material submitted in connection with an assessment
- (h) offering or providing a benefit, inducement or bribe to an Assessor, Moderator, Invigilator or other Assessment Participant
- (i) threatening, harassing or attempting to improperly influence an Assessor, Moderator, Invigilator or other Assessment Participant
- (j) any other conduct that ISEA reasonably determines to be inconsistent with the integrity of the assessment process.

10.2 Reporting

An Assessment Participant who becomes aware of suspected Examination Misconduct must report the matter promptly to the Responsible Committee. A Candidate or any other person may also report suspected Examination Misconduct, including through the channels established under the Whistleblower Policy.

10.3 Interim Measures

Where the Responsible Committee reasonably suspects Examination Misconduct, it may, pending investigation, withhold the Candidate’s results, suspend the Candidate’s participation in a further assessment component, or take such other interim measure as is reasonably necessary to protect the integrity of the assessment process. An interim measure under this Clause is not a finding of misconduct.

10.4 Investigation and Procedural Fairness

A suspected breach of this Clause shall be investigated in accordance with the Disciplinary Policy, which shall apply with such modifications as are necessary to reflect the assessment context. A Candidate the subject of an allegation of Examination Misconduct shall be given notice of the allegation, a reasonable opportunity to respond, and access to the evidence relied upon, save to the extent that disclosure would

itself compromise the integrity or security of the assessment for example, disclosure of confidential examination content to other Candidates.

10.5 Outcomes

Where Examination Misconduct is established, ISEA may impose one or more of the following outcomes, having regard to the nature and seriousness of the conduct, whether it was deliberate, reckless or inadvertent, and any other relevant circumstance:

- (k) a formal warning
- (l) a mark of zero for the affected assessment component
- (m) disqualification from the assessment cycle
- (n) a requirement to undertake reassessment, subject to a specified waiting period
- (o) a prohibition on reapplying for MISEA admission for a specified period
- (p) referral to a disciplinary process under the Disciplinary Policy, which may result in outcomes including those set out in the Ethics Policy and
- (q) such other outcome as ISEA considers proportionate to the conduct.

10.6 Record

A finding of Examination Misconduct, and the outcome imposed, shall be recorded in the Candidate's Assessment Record in accordance with Clause 20.

11. Plagiarism and Research Integrity

11.1 Definition

Plagiarism" means the presentation of another person's words, data, analysis, valuation model, structure or ideas as though they were the Candidate's own original work, without appropriate attribution, including where the material is copied, closely paraphrased, or substantially derived from a source without proper disclosure. Plagiarism includes the unattributed reproduction of material from published research, another Candidate's submission, a prior submission by the same Candidate, or output generated by artificial intelligence or another automated tool, whether or not the source is itself protected by copyright.

11.2 Standard Expected

A Candidate is expected to conduct independent research and to prepare each equity research report substantially through their own analysis, drawing on publicly available information, financial data and recognised research and valuation methodologies, and to clearly attribute any material fact, figure, data set, quotation or analytical framework drawn from an identifiable external source.

11.3 Self-Plagiarism and Re-Use

A Candidate must not submit, as new work for the Equity Research Assessment, material that substantially reproduces a report or analysis previously submitted by the Candidate to ISEA, to another professional body, to an academic institution, or to an employer, without prior written disclosure to and approval from ISEA. Re-use of a Candidate's own prior work without disclosure is treated as a form of Plagiarism for the purposes of this Policy.

11.4 Detection

ISEA may use similarity-detection software, comparison against prior submissions and publicly available research, and such other detection methods as it considers appropriate to identify potential Plagiarism. The absence of a positive result from any such tool does not, by itself, establish that a submission is free of Plagiarism, and a positive result does not, by itself, establish that Plagiarism has occurred. ISEA shall apply its judgement to all available evidence.

11.5 Consequences

Plagiarism constitutes Examination Misconduct for the purposes of Clause 10 and shall be dealt with in accordance with that Clause and, where applicable, the Disciplinary Policy.

12. Use of Artificial Intelligence and Technology

12.1 General Approach

ISEA recognises that artificial intelligence, data analytics, financial modelling software and other technologies are increasingly used in professional equity research, consistently with Clause 5.5 of the Ethics Policy. This Policy does not prohibit the responsible use of such technology in the preparation of a Candidate's research reports, but requires that such use be disclosed, that the Candidate retain personal responsibility for the analysis and conclusions submitted, and that such use not be permitted to substitute for the Candidate's own independent professional judgement, in a manner that would undermine the purpose of the Equity Research Assessment described in Clause 5.1.

12.2 Disclosure Obligation

A Candidate who uses artificial intelligence, automated analytics, large language models or comparable technology in the preparation of a research report must disclose that use in the report itself and in the declaration referred to in Clause 9.4, including a description of the tool used, the nature and extent of its use, and the steps taken by the Candidate to verify the accuracy, originality and appropriateness of any output relied upon.

12.3 Permitted and Impermissible Use

Permitted use may include, without limitation, the use of technology to support data gathering, financial modelling calculations, drafting assistance, proofreading or the organisation of research materials, provided the Candidate's own independent analysis, valuation judgement and investment conclusions are not displaced. Impermissible use includes, without limitation, the submission of an investment thesis, valuation conclusion, or substantial portion of analytical content generated by artificial intelligence or another automated tool and presented as the Candidate's own original analysis without disclosure, or the use of any technology, communication tool or artificial intelligence during the Controlled Written Case Examination or the Oral Defence, other than technology expressly authorised by ISEA for that assessment component.

12.4 Verification

The Oral Defence is an integral safeguard against inappropriate reliance on technology. A Candidate who cannot satisfactorily explain, defend or demonstrate understanding of the analysis, assumptions, methodology or conclusions contained in a research report may be assessed as not having demonstrated the independent analytical capability required by Clause 5.1, irrespective of whether any use of technology was disclosed.

12.5 Consequences of Non-Disclosure

Undisclosed or prohibited use of artificial intelligence or other technology constitutes Examination Misconduct for the purposes of Clause 10 and shall be dealt with in accordance with that Clause.

12.6 Evolving Guidance

ISEA may issue and update, from time to time, more detailed guidance concerning permitted and prohibited technology use in the Equity Research Assessment, consistently with this Policy, having regard to technological developments in the equity research profession.

13. Conflicts of Interest

13.1 Candidate Conflicts

A Candidate must disclose to ISEA any actual, potential or perceived conflict of interest arising in connection with the company assigned or proposed for a research report, including any financial interest, employment relationship, family relationship, advisory mandate, or other material connection between the Candidate and the company, its officers, or its major shareholders. ISEA may reject a proposed company, require an alternative company, or take such other action as it considers appropriate where a material conflict of interest is identified, consistently with Clause 16.5 of the Member Admission Framework.

13.2 Assessment Participant Conflicts

An Assessor, Moderator, Invigilator or other Assessment Participant must disclose to the Responsible Committee any actual, potential or perceived conflict of interest arising from a personal, family, financial, employment or commercial relationship with a Candidate, or from any other circumstance that may reasonably be perceived to affect their objectivity, before undertaking any function in relation to that Candidate's assessment.

13.3 Recusal and Reallocation

Where a conflict of interest is disclosed or identified under this Clause, the Responsible Committee shall determine whether the affected person should be recused from the relevant function, whether the matter should be reallocated to another Assessor, Moderator or Invigilator, or whether the conflict can otherwise be appropriately managed. A person who fails to disclose a conflict of interest known to them may be subject to removal under Clause 14.6 and, where applicable, referral under the Ethics Policy or the Disciplinary Policy.

13.4 Register

The Responsible Committee shall maintain a record of conflicts of interest disclosed under this Clause and the manner in which each conflict was managed, consistently with the Conflict of Interest Policy.

14. Assessors

14.1 Appointment

Assessors are appointed by the Responsible Committee. A person appointed as an Assessor must ordinarily hold MISEA or FISEA status, or possess equivalent demonstrated professional experience in equity research, investment analysis or a closely related discipline, and must have no disqualifying conflict of interest under Clause 13.

14.2 Role and Responsibilities

An Assessor is responsible for marking a Candidate's research reports, participating in or conducting the Oral Defence, and marking the Controlled Written Case Examination, in each case in accordance with the applicable marking rubric and the standards established by this Policy and the Member Admission Framework. An Assessor must exercise independent, objective and professionally defensible judgement and must not be influenced by any consideration other than the Candidate's demonstrated performance against the applicable assessment criteria.

14.3 Panel Composition

Wherever reasonably practicable, ISEA shall allocate more than one Assessor to a Candidate's assessment, including for the purposes of the Oral Defence, so as to reduce the risk of individual bias and to support consistent marking outcomes across the Equity Research Assessment.

14.4 Training and Calibration

ISEA shall provide Assessors with training on the applicable marking rubrics, assessment standards, integrity requirements and their obligations under this Policy, and shall conduct periodic calibration exercises to promote consistency of marking standards between Assessors and across assessment cycles.

14.5 Assessor Conduct

An Assessor must maintain the confidentiality of Candidate submissions, marks and deliberations in accordance with Clause 19, must treat Candidates with professionalism and courtesy, and must comply with the Ethics Policy and the Code in the performance of their assessment functions.

14.6 Removal

The Responsible Committee may remove an Assessor from a Candidate's assessment, or from the pool of Assessors generally, where the Assessor has an undisclosed or unmanaged conflict of interest, has breached this Policy, has demonstrated inconsistent or unreliable marking, or is otherwise unable to perform the role to the standard required.

15. Marking

15.1 Marking Framework

Unless an alternative assessment structure is authorised in accordance with the Member Admission Framework, the Equity Research Assessment shall be marked out of 100 marks, allocated as follows:

Component	Marks
Equity Research Report 1 ISEA- Assigned	25
Equity Research Report 2 Applicant- Selected	25
Oral Defence	25
Controlled Written Case Examination	25
Total	100

Each Equity Research Report shall be assessed out of 25 marks as follows:

Assessment Area	Marks
Financial statement analysis	5
Industry and competitive analysis	2.5
Valuation methodology	5

Assessment Area	Marks
Investment thesis quality	5
Risk assessment	2.5
Overall research quality and presentation	5
Total	25

The Oral Defence shall be assessed as follows:

Area	Marks
Understanding of submitted research	5
Defence of assumptions	5
Valuation judgement	5
Response to challenge	5
Independent professional judgement	5
Total	25

The Controlled Written Case Examination shall be assessed as follows:

Assessment Area	Marks
Financial analysis and modelling	7
Valuation judgement	6
Investment reasoning	5
Risk assessment	4
Ethics and professional standards	3
Total	25

15.2 Marking Rubrics

ISEA shall maintain detailed marking rubrics for each assessment area referred to in Clause 15.1, describing the standard of performance required to achieve each band of marks. Assessors must apply the applicable rubric and must record written justification for the marks awarded, sufficient to support moderation and, where applicable, appeal.

15.3 Anonymisation

Wherever reasonably practicable, research reports and Controlled Written Case Examination scripts shall be marked without the Assessor being aware of the Candidate's identity. Anonymisation is not practicable for the Oral Defence, given its interactive nature the additional safeguards in Clauses 13, 14.3 and 16 apply to that component to help preserve objectivity.

15.4 Pass Requirements

Consistently with Clause 19.6 of the Member Admission Framework, to achieve a pass in the Equity Research Assessment a Candidate must:

- (a) achieve an overall score of at least 75 out of 100
- (b) achieve at least 65% in each individual assessment component set out in Clause 15.1

A Candidate who achieves an overall score of 75 or more but does not achieve at least 65% in every individual assessment component has not satisfied the pass requirements of this Policy and shall be treated in accordance with Clause 17 Reassessment.

15.5 Provisional and Final Marks

Marks are provisional until they have been reviewed in accordance with the moderation procedures in Clause 16 and formally confirmed by the Responsible Committee. ISEA shall notify a Candidate of their

final result, including component-level marks, within the timeframe published for the relevant assessment cycle.

15.6 Feedback

A Candidate may request feedback on their performance in the Equity Research Assessment. ISEA shall provide feedback at a level of detail sufficient to assist the Candidate's professional development and, where applicable, preparation for reassessment, without disclosing confidential assessment content, individual Assessor identities, or the performance of other Candidates.

16. Moderation

16.1 Purpose

Moderation exists to promote consistency, fairness and defensibility of marking outcomes across Assessors, Candidates and assessment cycles, and to identify and correct marking errors or inconsistencies before results are finalised.

16.2 Second Marking

Where more than one Assessor has marked a component, the Responsible Committee shall review the marks awarded for material discrepancies. Where a material discrepancy exists between Assessors, the Responsible Committee shall refer the matter to a Moderator or a third Assessor for resolution.

16.3 Borderline Results

Every result that falls within five 5 marks of the overall pass threshold of 75, or within five 5 percentage points of the 65% component threshold in Clause 15.4, shall be independently reviewed by a Moderator before the result is finalised.

16.4 Statistical Review

The Responsible Committee shall periodically review aggregate marking data across Assessors and assessment cycles to identify any Assessor whose marking pattern is materially more lenient or more severe than the cohort average, and shall take such action, including further training, recalibration or reallocation of marking duties, as it considers appropriate.

16.5 External Moderation

The Responsible Committee shall arrange for periodic external moderation of the Equity Research Assessment, including review by a person independent of the Assessment Panel responsible for the assessment cycle under review, to provide an additional check on the consistency and defensibility of ISEA's marking standards over time.

16.6 Moderation Records

The Responsible Committee shall maintain a record of moderation activity undertaken under this Clause, including any adjustment made to a Candidate's marks as a result of moderation, in the Candidate's Assessment Record.

17. Reassessment

17.1 Grounds for Reassessment

Consistently with Clause 24 of the Member Admission Framework, a Candidate who does not achieve the pass requirements set out in Clause 15.4, or whose assessment is affected by a substantiated technical or administrative failure under Clause 7.7, may be permitted to undertake reassessment.

17.2 Waiting Period

Unless ISEA determines otherwise having regard to the circumstances of a particular Candidate, a Candidate who does not achieve the pass requirements set out in Clause 15.4 may reapply for reassessment no earlier than three 3 months, and in the case of a Candidate found to have committed

Examination Misconduct, no earlier than twelve 12 months, following notification of the result, subject to any longer period imposed under Clause 10.5.

17.3 Scope of Reassessment

Where a Candidate has achieved at least 65% in a given assessment component but has not achieved the overall pass mark, ISEA may, in its discretion, permit the Candidate to be reassessed only in the component or components in which the Candidate did not achieve the required standard, provided that reassessment occurs within the timeframe determined by ISEA. Where reassessment of a research report is required, ISEA shall assign a new company for the ISEA-Assigned Research Report and, where applicable, require a newly selected and approved company for the Applicant-Selected Research Report.

17.4 Full Reassessment

Where a Candidate does not achieve at least 65% in more than one component, where a substantial period has elapsed since the Candidate's original attempt, or where ISEA otherwise considers it necessary to preserve the validity of the assessment, ISEA may require the Candidate to undertake the full Equity Research Assessment again.

17.5 Number of Attempts

A Candidate may not undertake the Equity Research Assessment, in whole or in part, more than three 3 times in total, unless the Responsible Committee approves an additional attempt in exceptional circumstances. Where a Candidate does not achieve the pass requirements on their third attempt, the Candidate must satisfy any further professional development requirement determined by ISEA under Clause 24.3 of the Member Admission Framework before any further attempt will be considered.

17.6 Further Development

Where ISEA determines that a Candidate's unsuccessful attempt resulted from insufficient preparation rather than a lack of underlying professional capability, ISEA may require the Candidate to demonstrate further relevant professional development, additional Relevant Experience, or completion of recommended preparatory activities before being permitted to undertake reassessment.

17.7 Fees

A Candidate undertaking reassessment must pay the applicable reassessment fee determined by ISEA.

18. Appeals

18.1 Grounds for Appeal

A Candidate may appeal an assessment outcome only on one or more of the following grounds:

- (a) a material procedural irregularity occurred in the administration of the assessment that may reasonably have affected the outcome
- (b) the marking criteria or marking rubric applicable to the assessment was not properly applied
- (c) a reasonable apprehension of bias or an unmanaged conflict of interest affected an Assessor, Moderator or Invigilator involved in the Candidate's assessment or
- (d) new material evidence has come to light that could not, with reasonable diligence, have been obtained or presented before the assessment outcome was determined.

An appeal is not available merely because a Candidate disagrees with the professional or academic judgement properly exercised by an Assessor or Moderator in accordance with the applicable marking rubric. ISEA's appeal process exists to correct process and fairness failures, not to substitute the appeal body's own view of academic merit for that of the Assessors, provided the applicable marking criteria were properly applied.

18.2 Timeframe

A Candidate must lodge an appeal in writing, setting out the ground or grounds relied upon and the supporting evidence, within twenty-one 21 days of being notified of the relevant assessment outcome.

ISEA may extend this timeframe where the Candidate demonstrates a reasonable justification for the delay.

18.3 Appeal Body

An appeal shall be considered by an appeal panel constituted by the Responsible Committee, comprising persons who were not involved in the original assessment, marking or moderation of the Candidate's assessment and who have no conflict of interest in relation to the Candidate.

18.4 Process

The appeal panel shall review the Candidate's written submission, the relevant Assessment Record, and any further information it considers necessary, and shall provide the Candidate a reasonable opportunity to be heard, which may be in writing or, where the appeal panel considers it appropriate, in person or by videoconference.

18.5 Outcomes

Following its review, the appeal panel may:

- (e) dismiss the appeal and confirm the original result
- (f) direct that a component be remarked by a different Assessor or Assessors
- (g) direct that the Candidate be permitted to undertake reassessment of the affected component or components without the reassessment counting towards the limit in Clause 17.5
- (h) amend the Candidate's result, where the appeal panel is satisfied that a clear marking or procedural error affected the outcome or
- (i) make such other determination as the appeal panel considers appropriate to remedy the ground of appeal established.

18.6 Finality

A decision of the appeal panel is final and binding on ISEA and the Candidate in relation to the assessment outcome under appeal, subject only to any further right of review expressly available under the Charter or the Membership Regulations. The appeal panel's decision does not limit a Candidate's separate right to raise a complaint under the Complaints Policy concerning the conduct of any person involved in the assessment or appeal process.

18.7 Record

ISEA shall record the outcome of every appeal, and the reasons for that outcome, in the Candidate's Assessment Record.

19. Confidentiality

19.1 General Obligation

All persons participating in the administration, marking, moderation or review of an assessment must treat as confidential all Candidate submissions, marks, feedback, deliberations, Assessment Records and assessment content to which they have access, and must not disclose such information except as permitted by this Clause or required by law.

19.2 Permitted Disclosures

Confidential assessment information may be disclosed where:

- (a) the disclosure is required by law or by a regulatory or professional body with lawful authority to request the information
- (b) the disclosure is authorised under this Policy or another applicable ISEA procedure, including for the purposes of moderation, appeal or disciplinary process
- (c) the disclosure is necessary for the proper conduct of an investigation, appeal or disciplinary process under this Policy or the Disciplinary Policy
- (d) the disclosure is made to the Candidate concerning their own assessment, subject to Clause 19.3

- (e) the disclosure is necessary to protect the integrity of ISEA or its professional standards, including in relation to suspected Examination Misconduct or
- (f) the Candidate has provided informed written consent to the specific disclosure.

19.3 Candidate Access to Own Records

A Candidate may request access to their own Assessment Record, including their marks, applicable rubric-based feedback and moderation outcomes, subject to the redaction of information that would identify another Candidate, disclose confidential examination content not yet retired from use, or reveal the individual identity of an Assessor or Moderator where ISEA considers such redaction necessary to protect the future integrity of the assessment or the wellbeing of Assessment Participants.

19.4 Data Protection

Personal information collected in connection with an assessment shall be collected, used, stored and disclosed in accordance with the Privacy Policy and applicable data protection law.

19.5 Security of Assessment Materials

ISEA shall take reasonable technical and organisational measures to protect the security and confidentiality of examination questions, case materials, marking rubrics, Candidate submissions and Assessment Records against unauthorised access, alteration, loss or disclosure.

20. Retention of Assessment Records

20.1 Scope of Assessment Records

For the purposes of this Clause, Assessment Records include, without limitation: a Candidate's submitted research reports marking sheets and rubric-based assessments records of the Oral Defence, including any recording made of it Controlled Written Case Examination scripts and marks moderation records records of Reasonable Adjustments granted or declined records of Examination Misconduct investigations and outcomes appeal submissions and outcomes and Candidate declarations made under Clause 9.4.

20.2 Retention Periods

Subject to the Document Retention Policy and to any longer period required by law or by an active investigation, appeal or disciplinary process, ISEA shall retain Assessment Records as follows:

- (a) for a Candidate who is admitted to MISEA, the Candidate's Assessment Record shall be retained for the duration of the individual's membership of ISEA and for a minimum of seven 7 years following cessation of membership
- (b) for a Candidate who does not achieve a pass result, the Candidate's Assessment Record shall be retained for a minimum of seven 7 years following the date of the relevant assessment outcome, to support any reassessment, appeal or reapplication
- (c) records relating to a finding of Examination Misconduct shall be retained for a minimum of ten 10 years, or for such longer period as is necessary having regard to any related disciplinary or legal process and
- (d) aggregate, de-identified assessment data used for moderation, statistical review and quality assurance purposes under Clause 16 may be retained for such longer period as ISEA considers reasonably necessary for those purposes.

20.3 Secure Storage

Assessment Records shall be stored securely, with access restricted to persons who require access for a legitimate purpose connected with the administration, moderation, review, appeal or investigation of an assessment, or as otherwise permitted under Clause 19.

20.4 Destruction

On expiry of the applicable retention period, ISEA shall securely destroy or permanently de-identify Assessment Records, unless a longer retention period is required by law, by the Document Retention Policy, or by an active investigation, appeal or legal process.

20.5 Regulatory and Legal Access

ISEA may retain, and may be required to produce, Assessment Records in connection with a regulatory inquiry, legal proceeding, or lawful request by a professional or governmental body, notwithstanding the retention periods set out in Clause 20.2.

21. Review and Continuous Improvement

ISEA shall periodically review this Policy and the broader Equity Research Assessment framework to ensure that they remain appropriate having regard to:

- (a) developments in equity research, investment analysis and financial markets
- (b) international assessment and professional certification practices
- (c) regulatory and legal developments relevant to professional assessment
- (d) technological and artificial intelligence developments affecting assessment design and integrity
- (e) outcomes of moderation, appeals and Examination Misconduct investigations conducted under this Policy
- (f) feedback from Candidates, Assessors, Moderators and other Assessment Participants and
- (g) the evolving needs and competency expectations of the equity research profession.

The Responsible Committee shall recommend amendments to this Policy where appropriate, subject to approval by the Governing Council. Any amendment must remain consistent with the Charter, the Membership Regulations, the Membership and Chapters Committee Charter, the Membership Policy and the Member Admission Framework.

ISEA shall conduct a formal review of this Policy no less frequently than every twelve 12 months, and following any material incident affecting the integrity of an assessment, whether or not such incident resulted in a finding under Clause 10.

22. Effective Date

This Assessment and Examination Policy takes effect on the date approved by the Governing Council and applies to every assessment cycle commencing on or after that date. An assessment cycle already in progress on the effective date shall continue to be administered under the policy in force at the time the cycle commenced, unless the Responsible Committee determines that applying this Policy to that cycle would not prejudice any Candidate.